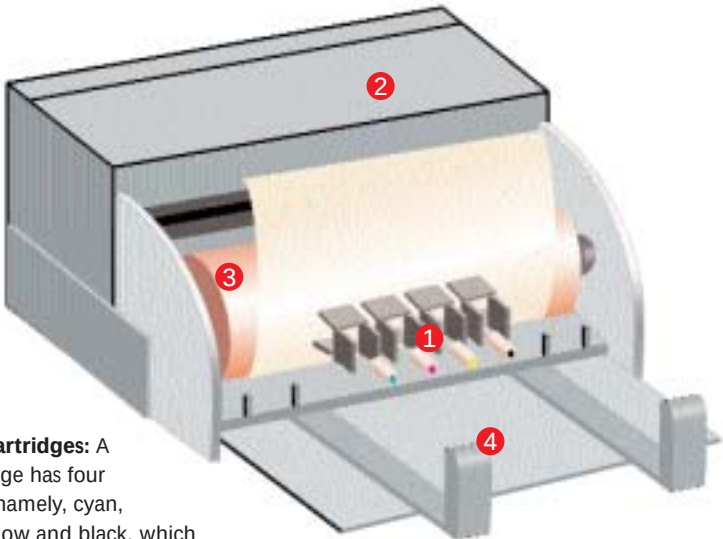




Buying Tips

- ✓ Opt for a printer with a USB interface since it offers higher data transfer speeds. If the printer offers both USB as well as parallel connectivity, then there's nothing like it.
- ✓ Consider the total cost of ownership and not just the purchase price. Vendors tend to sell off printers dirt-cheap. However, prices of cartridges are skyrocketing. Therefore, if you have huge volumes to print, even a difference of a rupee in the cost of the cartridge will save you a sizeable amount of cash over the lifetime of the printer.
- ✓ Check whether the printer supports additional features such as ink status determination via software, so that you can be sure of when to change the cartridge, and other features that add value.
- ✓ Inkjets using pigment-based inks are better than those using normal dye-based inks, as printouts taken with the former are smudge proof and water resistant. They also last longer.
- ✓ Choose a printer based on the kind of print quality you require. In general, Inkjet printers offer excellent quality as far as images and graphics are concerned, whereas laser printers offer better quality text printouts.
- ✓ If you're planning to buy an inkjet printer, make sure to check the page per minute (ppm) speed. Manufacturer-rated speeds are always in accordance with the printer's fastest mode of printing, and you're more likely to be printing in Normal or Best mode, which is much slower.
- ✓ If you intend to share the printer over a network, look for a higher buffer memory. The more the better.
- ✓ If you are buying a printer for photo printouts, always take a test print to check for quality. Some printers require a separate ink cartridge for photo quality printouts, while some don't. Make it a point to check for this, as it affects the price.
- ✓ Check the manufacturer's Web site for the type of support they offer, whether they offer regular software updates, patches for new operating systems, etc.



- 1 **Colour cartridges:** A colour cartridge has four types of ink, namely, cyan, magenta, yellow and black, which are combined to produce the colours on the paper.
- 2 **Front panel controls:** The front panel controls can be used instead of software, for printing.
- 3 **Rollers:** The paper is fed in and out of the printer by the roller.
- 4 **Paper tray:** The paper is fed into the printer using this tray.

Do Remember

- Check whether the printer will fit on your desktop. You might buy a 21-Inch printer only to find you don't have big enough a table.

Facts

- The nozzle head of an Inkjet printer opens and closes 5000 times per second while printing.
- Typically, ink drops have a volume of 8-10 picolitres (a million millionth of a litre).
- Inkjet printers allow for photo-realistic prints even on plain paper.



Quick Find	
YOU NEED	An inkjet printer to print resumes, letters, Web site contents and some occasional photo printouts. It can be cheap and speed can be compromised upon
Basic Use	
LOOK FOR	A basic A4 printer that has decent speed, prints in colour and comes with warranty and support
YOU NEED	An inkjet printer that prints text and combination documents with good quality and at high speeds
Inter Use	
LOOK FOR	A printer that offers good speed and has adequate connectivity options such as USB, parallel, network, IrDA, etc.
YOU NEED	An inkjet printer that prints high-resolution, photo-realistic, vibrant prints
Prof Use	
LOOK FOR	A printer that supports the highest resolution possible, has separate ink tanks and produces excellent photo printouts

The Future

The advocates of paperless environments had predicted the death of the printer. Indeed, concepts such as e-mail, e-paper, e-books and digital collaboration have taken us a step closer to a paperless work culture, but the inkjet printer is here to stay.

Once the norm, the dot-matrix printer is now limited to billing and accounting applications.

The past few months have seen the emergence of a new breed of inkjet printer, called the photo-printer, which connect directly to a digital camera and get printouts directly from it. They are lightweight and compact in size, thereby allowing complete portability.